

Sorites paradox



Many philosophers have found paradoxes useful, helping to clarify ideas by taking them to a logical, if absurd, conclusion. One of the best known is the 'liar paradox' associated with Epimenides of Crete who asserted that 'Cretans are always liars'. While some paradoxes can be shown to use invalid logical reasoning, others point to failings of logic itself. One example is the 'sorites paradox' (from the Greek *soros*, a heap). One grain of sand is obviously not a heap, and nor are two grains of sand, or even three ... and if we continue this progression then 10,000 grains don't make a heap either!

The problem here is with our system of logic, where things are either true or false; it's either a heap or not a heap, and there's nothing in between. Another version of this paradox is that of the balding man – but here we can at least recognize various degrees of thinning. The shortcomings of 'bivalent' logic can also be seen in other areas of philosophy, such as ethics, where it may be too simple to think in terms of right and wrong.